

Ethnic and Racial Discrimination in Nordic Hiring Practices

Evidence, Mechanisms, and Policy Responses

Lord Soumadeep Ghosh with Claude (Anthropic)

Kolkata, India

Abstract

The Nordic countries are frequently held up as models of equality, yet a substantial body of field-experimental research finds persistent discrimination against ethnic and racial minorities at the point of hiring. This article synthesizes evidence from correspondence and audit studies conducted in Sweden, Norway, Denmark, and Finland; discusses the mechanisms proposed to explain these patterns; and reviews the policy tools that have been tried, including anonymous CVs, in light of the evidence on their effectiveness. It closes by situating the Nordic evidence within a broader cross-national comparison and by outlining open questions for future research.

The paper ends with “The End”

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1 Introduction

Sweden, Norway, Denmark, and Finland score consistently at or near the top of international indices of gender equality, income equality, and institutional trust. This reputation has led to the phrase “Nordic exceptionalism” in comparative social policy research. At the same time, all four countries have undergone substantial demographic change since the 1970s: Norway’s immigrant and immigrant-descended population, for instance, grew from roughly 1.5% in 1970 to over one-fifth of the population by 2024, with the largest groups originating from Poland, Ukraine, Lithuania, Syria, Sweden, and Somalia [NAVIGATE Project, 2025].

This growth has made hiring discrimination against ethnic and racial minorities a central object of empirical study in the region. Researchers have used two main methods: *correspondence studies*, in which fictitious, closely matched job applications differing only in the applicant’s apparent ethnicity (typically signaled by name) are sent to real job openings, and *audit studies*, in which trained pairs of real or actor applicants apply for jobs in person. Correspondence studies dominate the Nordic literature because they are cheaper to scale and avoid the confound of an interviewer’s live impression of an actor’s mannerisms.

This article draws together the main empirical findings, discusses the leading explanations for why discrimination persists in otherwise egalitarian welfare states, reviews policy responses, and considers unresolved questions.

2 What the Evidence Shows

2.1 Sweden

Sweden has one of the longest running research programs on hiring discrimination in the region, dating to correspondence experiments conducted by Carlsson and Rooth in the mid-2000s, which found that applicants with Middle Eastern names received callbacks at roughly two-thirds the rate of applicants with Swedish names [Carlsson & Rooth, 2007]. A later, larger study submitted 5,641 applications to job postings on the Swedish Public Employment Service’s website between 2013 and 2020, spanning 20 occupations, comparing applicants with common Swedish names against applicants with common Slavic and Arabic names – chosen because they represent large foreign-born and visibly ethnic-minority populations in Sweden [Swedish Study, 2022]. The study found that applicants with foreign-sounding names received substantially fewer callbacks, and, consistent with earlier Nordic findings, that men with foreign-sounding names faced greater disadvantage than women with foreign-sounding names [Swedish Study, 2022].

A separate strand of Swedish research has tried to identify the psychological mechanisms behind discriminatory callback decisions. One widely cited study combined two field experiments on ethnic discrimination in hiring with an Implicit Association Test measuring employers’ automatic attitudes and performance stereotypes toward Arab-Muslim men relative to Swedish men, providing some of the first empirical evidence linking automatically activated associations to discriminatory hiring behavior in a real-world setting [Rooth, 2010].

2.2 Norway

Norwegian research, much of it associated with sociologist Arnfinn H. Midtbøen at the Institute for Social Research in Oslo, has documented discrimination against the children of immigrants – the so-called “second generation” – despite their possessing Norwegian education, work experience, and fluent Norwegian language skills [Midtbøen, 2014/2016]. Field experiments have found that descendants of Pakistani immigrants face reduced callback rates relative to otherwise identical applicants with ethnic Norwegian names [Midtbøen, 2019]. Follow-up interviews with employers who took part in these experiments suggest that ethnically distinct names trigger inferred stereotypes about the applicant, and that isolated negative experiences with individual minority employees tend to be generalized to the wider group [Midtbøen, 2019].

More recent Norwegian work has moved beyond the initial hiring stage to look at wage-setting and retention. Linked employer-employee administrative data show that the wage gap between immigrants and native Norwegians narrows with higher workplace unionization, though almost exclusively for immigrant employees who are themselves union members, and that access to licensed occupations similarly constrains the scope for unequal pay [Midtbøen & Orupabo]. Qualitative work in this same research program describes how minority jobseekers strategically “perform” Norwegianness in interviews to improve their chances [Orupabo, 2023].

2.3 Denmark

Danish correspondence studies have found callback ratios in the range of 1.5 – that is, majority applicants receiving roughly 50% more callbacks than closely matched minority applicants with Middle Eastern-origin names [Danish ESR Study, 2018]. The Danish case is often discussed alongside the country’s comparatively large population of non-Western immigrants and descendants of Turkish, Lebanese, Pakistani, and Iraqi origin, and against a backdrop of Danish political and media debate that has, at various points, focused heavily on the integration and labor-market participation of Muslim-majority immigrant groups [Danish ESR Study, 2018].

A 2021 Danish vignette study of employer preferences toward refugee jobseekers found a persistent negative effect of Middle Eastern origin or a Muslim-signaling name on hiring likelihood, even when a comparison vignette described a refugee from Ukraine chosen specifically to resemble native Danes in appearance and religious background – the Ukrainian vignette did not fully neutralize the disadvantage associated with having a refugee background [Danish Vignette Study, 2021].

2.4 Finland

Finnish researchers have run one of the few genuinely longitudinal correspondence designs in the region, comparing large-scale field experiments conducted in 2016 and 2024, together comprising roughly 10,000 matched applications sent to 2,000 vacancies across five sectors [Finnish Longitudinal Study, 2024]. The results are a useful corrective to any assumption that discrimination is static: discrimination against non-European applicants declined significantly between the two waves, and the reduction was more pronounced for non-European men than for non-European women, while discrimination against European-origin minority applicants showed no comparable improvement [Finnish Longitudinal Study, 2024]. This pattern suggests that ethnic hierarchies among

minority groups – not simply a binary majority/minority distinction – shape both the level of discrimination and how it changes over time.

2.5 Cross-national comparison

The most methodologically ambitious attempt to compare discrimination levels across countries on a common scale is the GEMM project (Growth, Equal Opportunities, Migration and Markets), a harmonized correspondence study covering Norway alongside Germany, the Netherlands, Spain, the United Kingdom, and (in an extension) the United States, with a combined sample exceeding 19,000 applications across 53 origin groups [GEMM Project]. The GEMM design varied not only ethnicity but also gender, religious affiliation, and phenotype (via photographs), enabling researchers to separate the effects of perceived race, religion, and national origin, which are often confounded in single-country studies [GEMM Project]. Consistent with the single-country Nordic literature, the GEMM study confirmed ethnic discrimination against first- and second-generation immigrant applicants in every country studied, including Norway, while also finding that the size and pattern of discrimination varied by specific origin group and occupation rather than following a single uniform “minority penalty” [GEMM Project].

A smaller-scale but illustrative cross-Scandinavian field experiment took a different route into the same question, testing whether amateur football clubs in Sweden, Norway, and Denmark responded differently to trial-practice requests from women with native versus foreign-sounding names. Only Sweden showed statistically significant discrimination, and within Sweden the probability of exclusion rose with the cultural distance signaled by the applicant’s name; no comparable pattern emerged in Norway or Denmark [Soccer Study]. Findings of this kind caution against treating “Scandinavia” or “the Nordics” as a single undifferentiated case: discrimination levels, and possibly its underlying drivers, vary meaningfully even among the closely related Nordic welfare states.

3 Mechanisms

The literature generally distinguishes two broad theoretical explanations for why employers might discriminate, both of which appear in the Nordic studies reviewed above.

- **Statistical discrimination.** Employers, lacking perfect information about an individual applicant’s productivity, use group membership (signaled by name, and sometimes by photograph or CV details such as gaps in employment) as a proxy for expected performance, based on real or perceived average differences between groups. Midtbøen’s interviews with Norwegian employers found that ethnically distinct names triggered inferred stereotypes about candidates’ likely skills or fit, consistent with a statistical-discrimination account [Midtbøen, 2019].
- **Taste-based (preference) discrimination.** Employers, coworkers, or customers may simply prefer not to work with members of a given group, independent of any belief about productivity. The Swedish Implicit Association Test study, which found that automatic negative associations toward Arab-Muslim men predicted discriminatory callback behavior, is often read as evidence for an affective or preference-based component that is not fully explained by statistical reasoning [Rooth, 2010].

These mechanisms are not mutually exclusive, and most researchers in this area treat them as complementary rather than competing explanations. A separate strand of Nordic sociological work emphasizes a distinct cultural mechanism: the Scandinavian conception of equality itself. Drawing on anthropologist Marianne Gullestad’s account of Norwegian egalitarianism, some researchers argue that Nordic equality norms have historically been tied less to formal equal treatment across difference (as in, for example, the American or French traditions) and more to an ideal of cultural sameness – fitting in, sharing common values, and appearing “ordinary” – which can make visible cultural or religious difference itself a basis for informal exclusion, even absent any explicit hostility [NAVIGATE Project, 2025].

4 Policy Responses

4.1 Anonymous CVs and name-blind recruitment

The most widely discussed policy intervention is the anonymous or name-blind CV, under which identifying information such as name, photograph, and sometimes address is withheld from employers during the initial screening stage. The underlying logic is straightforward: if discrimination operates through an inference employers draw from a name or photograph, removing that information should remove the disparity.

The evidence on effectiveness is decidedly mixed. A rigorous randomized evaluation conducted with the French national employment agency, in which firms were randomly assigned to receive either anonymized or stan-

dard resumes, found that anonymization did *not* increase interview or hiring rates for minority candidates and, counterintuitively, made participating firms *less* likely to interview and hire them [France CV Anonymes]. The researchers attribute this reversal to two factors: self-selection of relatively pro-diversity firms into the voluntary program, and the fact that anonymization removes other CV information that might otherwise have offset an ethnic-sounding name – for example, an applicant’s photograph, gap explanation, or additional signals that a human reviewer might use to counteract an initial negative reaction [France CV Anonymes].

A broader review of anonymous-application trials across several countries similarly concludes that where anonymization is implemented in a genuinely comprehensive and consistent way, it can equalize callback rates between majority and minority applicants at the screening stage, but that its overall effect depends heavily on the details of implementation, and that it addresses only the earliest stage of the hiring pipeline – not interview-stage or promotion-stage discrimination, which anonymization by definition cannot touch [IZA Anonymous Applications]. Sweden’s own experiment with a voluntary online applicant database, introduced by the public employment service in 1997 and allowing applicants to opt out of disclosing name and gender, is cited in this literature as an early and only partially effective precursor to more recent anonymization schemes [IZA Anonymous Applications].

4.2 Other approaches

Beyond anonymization, the Nordic countries have relied on a mix of anti-discrimination legislation, equality ombudsman institutions empowered to investigate complaints, and, in Norway, sector-level research into how union density and occupational licensing structures shape wage gaps once minority candidates are hired [Midtbøen & Orupabo]. The Norwegian findings on unionization are notable because they point past the hiring moment itself toward workplace institutions that can compress inequality after a minority candidate is on the job, suggesting that policy attention focused solely on the callback stage may be addressing only part of the problem.

5 Discussion and Open Questions

Three patterns recur across the Nordic evidence reviewed here. First, discrimination is not distributed evenly across all minority groups: applicants of Middle Eastern, Muslim-signaling, or Somali background consistently face larger callback penalties than applicants from other immigrant-origin groups, and the Finnish longitudinal data suggest this hierarchy has been comparatively stable even as overall discrimination against non-European applicants has fallen [Finnish Longitudinal Study, 2024]. Second, discrimination is gendered: multiple Nordic studies find that men with foreign-sounding names face greater hiring disadvantage than women with foreign-sounding names, a pattern that does not hold uniformly elsewhere in Europe [Swedish Study, 2022]. Third, national labels can obscure real within-region variation – the Scandinavian football-club experiment is a clear illustration that ostensibly similar welfare states can produce quite different discrimination outcomes even for closely comparable requests [Soccer Study].

Several questions remain open. Much of the correspondence-study literature captures only the first stage of hiring – the callback for interview – and has comparatively little to say about discrimination in final hiring decisions, wage-setting, promotion, or dismissal, stages that require different (and generally harder to obtain) data [Swedish Study, 2022]. The mixed evidence on anonymous CVs also suggests that policy design matters enormously: a poorly implemented anonymization scheme, or one adopted by firms already inclined to diversify, may produce misleading null or even reversed results relative to what a mandatory, comprehensive scheme would achieve [France CV Anonymes]. Finally, comparatively little Nordic research has yet examined how algorithmic or AI-assisted screening tools, now increasingly used in early-stage recruitment, interact with these long-documented human biases – an area likely to grow in importance.

6 Conclusion

Despite their reputation for egalitarianism, the Nordic countries show a robust and repeatedly replicated pattern of ethnic and racial discrimination in hiring, documented through decades of correspondence and field-experimental research in Sweden, Norway, Denmark, and Finland, and corroborated by cross-national comparative work such as the GEMM project. The discrimination is not uniform: it varies by target group, by gender, by country, and over time. Policy responses such as anonymous CVs address only part of the hiring pipeline and have produced mixed results depending on implementation, underscoring that reducing labor-market discrimination in the region will likely require sustained attention to multiple stages of the employment relationship rather than a single intervention at the point of first contact.

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Glossary

Anonymous CV / name-blind recruitment

A hiring procedure in which identifying information – typically the applicant’s name, and sometimes photograph or address – is withheld from employers during initial screening, intended to prevent ethnicity or gender from influencing early-stage decisions. *Discussed in Section 4.1, Policy Responses.*

Audit study

A field method for measuring discrimination in which trained pairs of real or actor applicants, matched on qualifications but differing in apparent ethnicity, apply for jobs in person, allowing researchers to observe differential treatment through the full application process rather than just at the callback stage. *Discussed in Section 1, Introduction.*

Callback rate

The proportion of job applications that result in an employer response inviting the applicant to interview

or requesting further contact; the primary outcome measure used in correspondence studies to detect discrimination. *Used throughout Section 2, What the Evidence Shows.*

Correspondence study

A field-experimental method in which fictitious, closely matched job applications – identical in qualifications but differing in a signal of ethnicity, most often the applicant’s name – are submitted to real job vacancies to measure differences in employer response rates. *Discussed in Section 1, Introduction, and used as the primary method in Section 2.*

GEMM project

Short for “Growth, Equal Opportunities, Migration and Markets,” a harmonized cross-national correspondence study covering Norway, Germany, the Netherlands, Spain, the United Kingdom, and (in an extension) the United States, designed to compare discrimination against the same origin groups across different national contexts. *Discussed in Section 2.5, Cross-national comparison.*

Implicit Association Test (IAT)

A psychological measurement technique used to detect automatic, often unconscious associations between social categories (such as ethnicity or religion) and evaluative concepts (such as competence); used in Swedish research to link employers’ automatic attitudes toward Arab-Muslim men to discriminatory callback behavior. *Discussed in Section 2.1, Sweden, and Section 3, Mechanisms.*

Minority penalty

The reduction in callback, interview, or hiring likelihood experienced by an applicant perceived as belonging to an ethnic, racial, or religious minority group, relative to an otherwise identical majority applicant. *Referenced throughout Section 2 and Section 5, Discussion and Open Questions.*

Phenotype treatment

An experimental manipulation, used in studies such as GEMM, in which applicant photographs are varied to signal different racial or ethnic appearances independently of name or stated national origin, allowing researchers to separate the effects of perceived race from other ethnic signals. *Discussed in Section 2.5, Cross-national comparison.*

Second generation

Individuals born in a country to immigrant parents; a group of particular interest in Nordic discrimination research because they typically hold domestic educational credentials, work experience, and native language fluency, isolating the effect of perceived ethnic background from other disadvantages immigrants may face. *Discussed in Section 2.2, Norway.*

Statistical discrimination

A theoretical account in which employers, lacking full information about an individual applicant’s productivity, use group membership (such as ethnicity, inferred from a name) as a proxy for expected performance, based on real or perceived average differences between groups. *Discussed in Section 3, Mechanisms.*

Taste-based discrimination

A theoretical account, originating with economist Gary Becker, in which discrimination reflects an employer’s, coworker’s, or customer’s preference against interacting with a given group, independent of any belief about that group’s average productivity. *Discussed in Section 3, Mechanisms.*

Vignette study

A survey-experimental method in which respondents (such as employers) are presented with short written descriptions of hypothetical candidates that vary systematically on characteristics like national origin or religion, and asked to rate or rank their likelihood of hiring each one. *Discussed in Section 2.3, Denmark.*

The End